

Overdose Emergency Department Visits in Virginia

Background

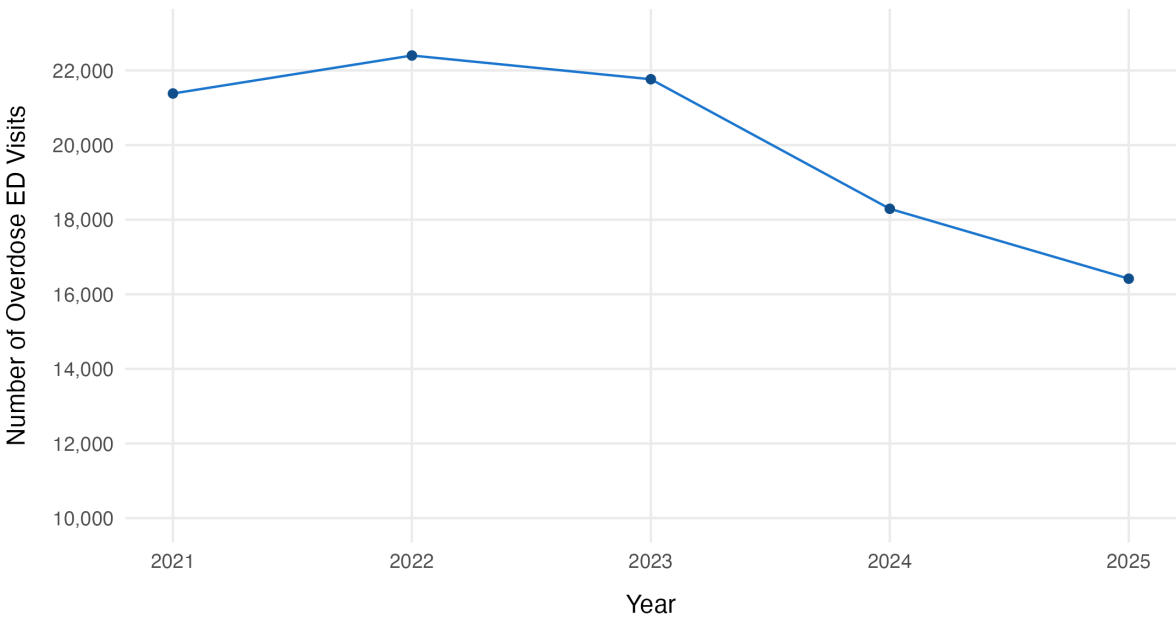
Understanding the need for effective policymaking related to drug overdoses, this infographic explores trends in Virginia drug overdose emergency department (ED) visits.

Data Sources

The visualizations in this infographic were created based on data from the Virginia Department of Health. Specifically, the “VDH PUD Overdose ED Visits by Health Region and Month”¹ and “VDH PUD Overdose ED Visits by Year and Geography”² datasets were used.

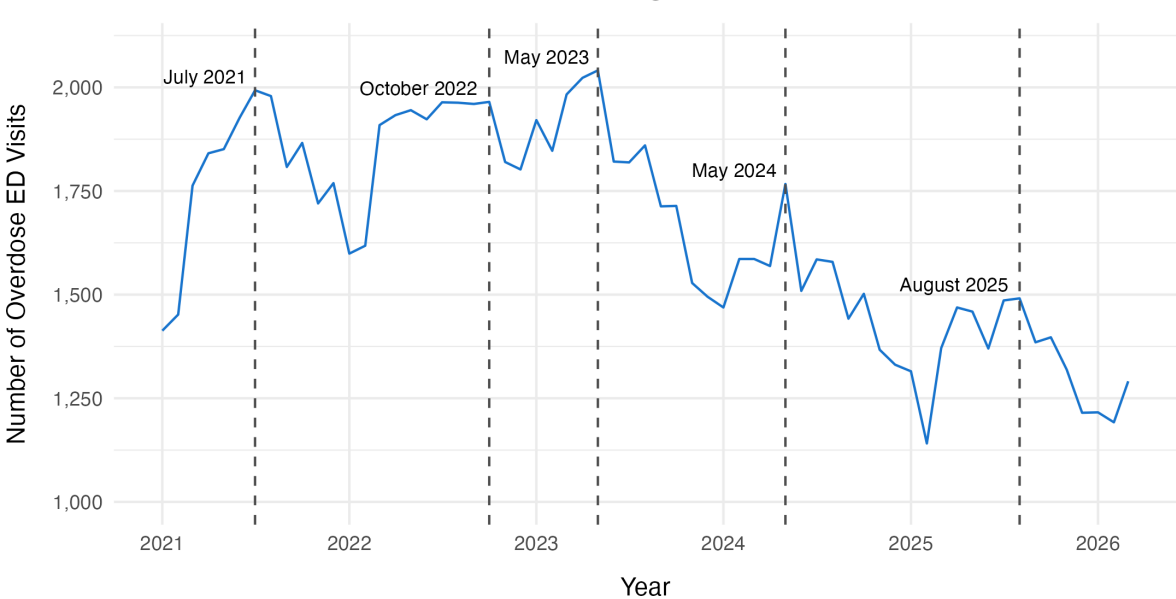
These line graphs show that in Virginia, the number of drug overdose ED visits have generally been decreasing in the past several years. While these visit numbers follow seasonal trends and tend to spike in the middle of the year, the overall trend is one of decline.

Overall Downward Trend in Virginia Overdose Emergency Department Visits



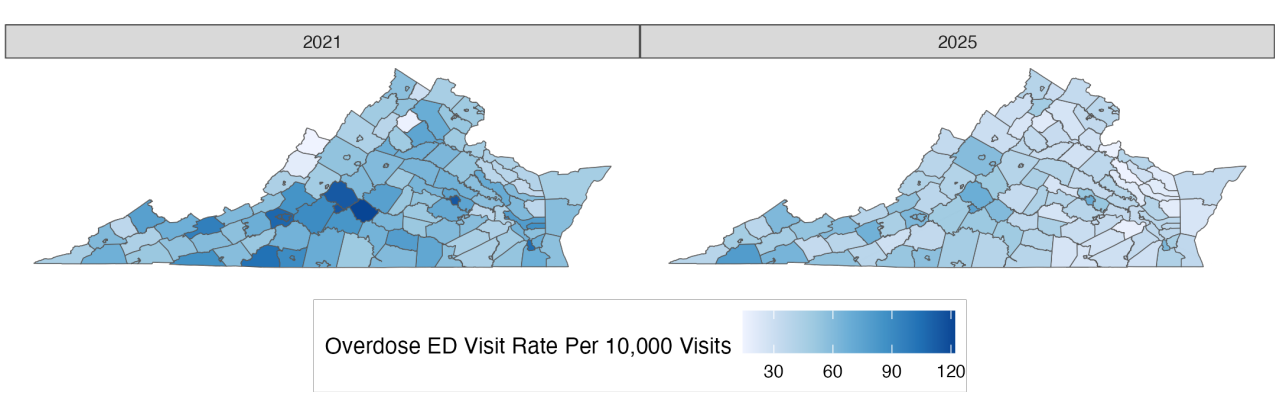
Note: The y-axis does not begin at 0

Virginia Overdose Emergency Department Visits Are Falling While Following Seasonal Trends



Note: The y-axis does not begin at 0
Yearly maximum visit numbers are shown with vertical lines

Decrease in Overdose Emergency Department Visit Rate Per 10,000 Visits in Most Localities



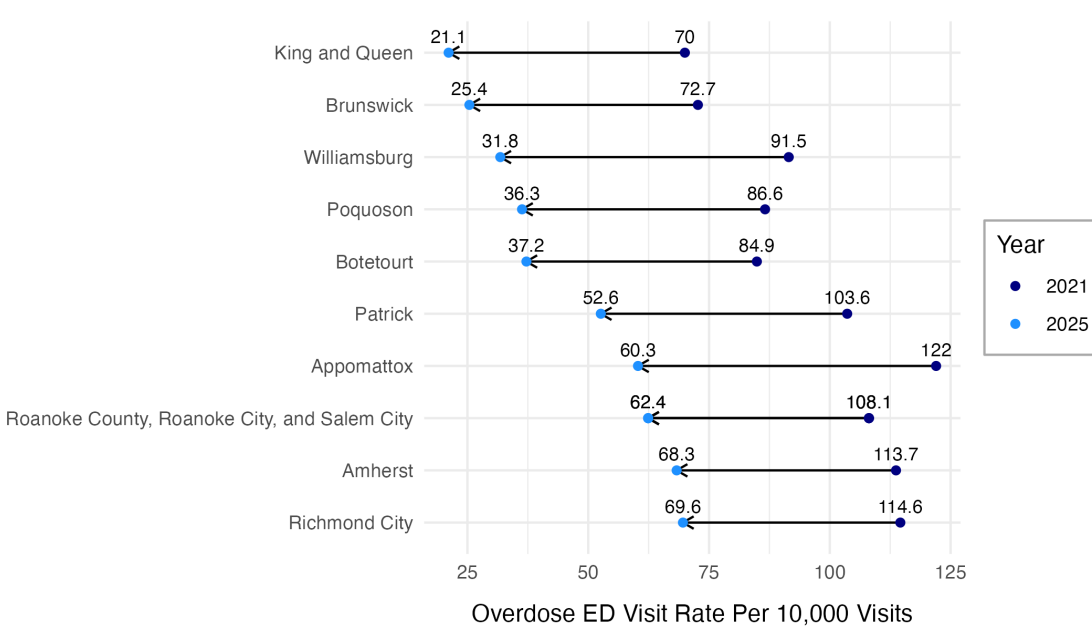
The downward trend in overdose ED visits at the state level is also experienced at the local level. As shown in the maps, most localities in Virginia had a decrease in their rate of overdose ED visits from 2021 to 2025.

Some localities experienced significant drops in their overdose ED visit rates. The barbell plot shows the differences in these rates from 2021 to 2025 for the ten localities that experienced the largest decrease.

Potential Explanations

There could be several explanations for decreasing overdose ED visits in recent years. This may reflect the lessening of the impacts of COVID-19, as overdose ED visits increased during the pandemic.³ This may also reflect the effects of Virginia state-level policies implemented to address overdoses, such as Operation Free Virginia.⁴

Several Localities Experienced Large Decreases in Overdose Emergency Department Visit Rates



Conclusion

To encourage the continuation of these trends, further research should be conducted to determine the causes of decreased overdose ED visits. This will promote effective policymaking related to drug overdoses.

Sources

- <https://data.virginia.gov/dataset/vdh-pud-overdose-ed-visits-by-health-region-and-month>
- <https://data.virginia.gov/dataset/vdh-pud-overdose-ed-visits-by-year-and-geography>
- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8449788/>
- <https://www.vaemergenc y.gov/operation-free-virginia>